

MojoPac

www.mojopac.com

If you're the my-USB-stick-is-my-everything type, this one's for you. MojoPac is a utility that installs on your USB drive (broadly, any hardware that your PC recognises as a Mass Storage Device—your phone, your PMP, and more) and gives you a virtual Windows XP desktop on each computer you plug this drive into. It's almost like logging on to your own computer—your settings, your wallpaper, your programs, someone else's hardware and someone else's Windows XP.

Here's how it works—MojoPac uses the existing Windows OS on the *host computer* (the PC you're working on) to create a new working environment for you. This environment is insulated from that of the host PC, so none of the changes you make to this environment will affect the host PC. Your USB drive becomes your new C: drive, which also means you won't have access to the programs installed on the host PC—a security feature

Are you tired of pretending to pay for software? Is the guilt too much? Not enough seeds? Take a break and check out some of the best freeware tools ever made

that protects the host PC from your activities. You can, however, install your own programs—even games—in your environment just like you would on any Windows PC, and they'll be available to you wherever you connect your drive—it's practically like carrying your own computer around!

Traveller's Tip

To optimise the performance of your drive, open My Computer on the host PC, right-click on your USB drive and choose Properties. Under Hardware, select the USB drive and choose Properties. In the dialog that pops up, you'll see that "Optimize for quick removal" is selected by default—change this to "Optimize for Performance".

The Alternative

There's no tool that offers the virtual desktop that MojoPac does, but if what you want is the ability to carry your programs around with you, there's the Portable Apps Suite (www.portableapps.com/suite), that bundles Firefox, OpenOffice.org and many open source tools that can be run off a USB drive without changing the settings on your host PC.

Maya 8.5 Personal Learning Edition

<http://usa.autodesk.com/adsk/servlet/index?siteID=123112&id=7639525>

Maya is among the best tools ever made for 3D modelling, animation and special effects. It isn't, however, the easiest to learn, and your only recourse (if you wanted to go about things legally) would have been to take some rather expensive lessons. Maya Personal Learning Edition (PLE), however, changed that.

Maya PLE is clearly geared to letting you learn modelling only—while you get all the tools you need to learn how to model in 3D, many other options are quite limited—the output resolution is limited to 1024 x 768 and all your renders are watermarked. You won't even be able to save your work in the default Maya file format—the PLE has its own .mp format, which isn't compatible with the commercial version. Despite these restrictions, this still gets our favour for the simple reason that it gives you access to the same tools that the professionals use. If you're looking to make a career in 3D graphics later in your life, knowing Maya is a big plus. And then, there's that interface.

The Alternative

Maya's interface is more than unconventional, but has some really neat tricks up its sleeve. The

right-click menu gives you the most useful commands arranged in a circle, which makes them easier to access—once you get used to them, you'll subconsciously remember the angle to move your mouse at. In the top-right corner of the main viewport (that's where you can see your model), you'll see a cube with arrows pointing to each side. When you click on an arrow, the view shifts to show you your model from that angle—click on the arrow on the top to see a top view, for example. This, naturally, is far better than fiddling with View menus.

The Alternative

Blender (www.blender.org) is an open source 3D modelling tool that holds its own against other professional tools as well. Its interface, however, is even more incomprehensible than Maya's and can be very disorienting. Then again, it's free, without restrictions, and has a bunch of plugins available for it.

Opera

www.opera.com

Firefox may be the alternative browser of choice, but it was Opera that started the tabbed browsing revolution. Now, it features an inbuilt e-mail client, IRC client and RSS reader. It's also renders Web pages faster than any other browser. The latest version—9.5—also features Opera Link, which lets you send bookmarks and other settings online, and synchronise them with other copies of Opera you might use—including Opera Mini on your mobile.

One of Opera's best features is its support for mouse gestures—you can perform a multitude of tasks by holding down the right mouse button and moving the mouse a certain way. Holding down right-click, moving the mouse downwards and releasing, for example, opens a new tab. Other neat features include Fast Forward, which automatically detects "Next Page" links so you can navigate forward using a mouse gesture instead of hunting for the link yourself. You can also set Opera to masquerade as IE or Firefox for sites that call it an "unsupported browser".

Google doesn't love Opera, though, so you'll find that Google's online applications revert to



their older versions with Opera. However, by using Mask as Firefox, everything sets itself right.

Keyboard Warrior's Tip

Another important part of Opera's awesomeness is that you can go through an entire session of browsing without ever touching the mouse. To cycle through all the links on a page, hold down [Shift] and use the arrows to move from one link to the next. The program's also smart enough to start highlighting only links in the visible portions of the Web page. Hit [Enter] to visit a link, [Shift] + [Enter] to open it in a new tab, and [Ctrl] + [Shift] + [Enter] to open it in a new tab without shifting focus from your current tab. You can also use [1] and [2] to navigate between tabs.

The Alternative

Firefox (www.getfirefox.com) is the world's second most popular browser, and is catching up fast. While it doesn't have all of Opera's features when you install it, you can extend its functionality using some of the many extensions that enthusiasts are developing for it.

Google Desktop

<http://desktop.google.com>

It's Google search. For your PC. How could it not be filled with goodness? Google Desktop starts where Windows' (or Linux's, for that matter) default search ends. You also get a Vista-like sidebar, complete with Google Gadgets—though the gadgets available are quite underwhelming. Even better, you can turn off this sidebar and opt for the simple-dialog-box approach.

The simple [Ctrl] + [Ctrl] shortcut becomes your ticket to everything—you can use Google Desktop to launch applications, rifle through your music collection, search for text within documents, search the Web, even look into your Gmail. Google Desktop caches everything it indexes, so even if you've deleted a file, the cache will let you view its contents. The best part? All this happens as you type.

Googler's Tip

For Google Desktop to work effectively, it needs to index your hard disc/s, which can take time. Configure it to index all your discs (you can do this in Preferences) and leave it overnight. When you come back to your PC in the morning, you'll have all you need at your fingertips.

The Alternative

Copernic Desktop Search (<http://www.copernic.com/en/products/desktop-search/index.html>) is one of the first desktop search applications to ever

FREE
RIDE

Nimish Chandiramani